amphitheatre found in ancient India. Known as Vijayapuri, it was the capital city of the Ikshvaku Kingdom (c. 220–320 CE) and a great religious and educational centre of Buddhism and Brahminism that actively traded with the Roman Empire.

Sadly, much of the site of ancient Vijayapuri now lies submerged under one of the largest manmade lakes in the world, Nagarjuna Sagar, formed in 1960 by a dam across the Krishna River. Fortunately, before the site was submerged, a large team of archaeologists was given six years to excavate, study and relocate the most important structures of Vijayapuri on higher ground, on a hill in the valley called Nagarjunakonda (‘Hill of Nagarjuna’, now an island on the lake), and on the lake’s eastern bank at Anupu. History buffs visit these two locations today.

I first visited Nagarjunakonda in December 2005. Heading west on a bus from Vijayawada, I passed towns and villages whose names— opaque to me because they were written only in Telugu—I kept guessing at from a paper map. The region was then infamous for years of deficient rains and drought, depleted water tables and farmers either fleeing to other regions or committing suicide to escape debt.

Thirteen years later, in September 2018, I begin again in Vijayawada, which is abuzz with new energy and enterprise owing to the state government’s interim relocation here, after Andhra Pradesh was carved into two states and Hyderabad became the capital of the new Telangana state in 2014. Billboards in town show portly leaders, in traditional attire and folded hands, seeking votes for the upcoming state elections. Unlike my previous journey to Nagarjunakonda, I hire a taxi and track our drive with GPS on an alternative route.

It is late monsoon and the rains have been weak yet again. We cross the north-eastern Guntur district, where the green fields of cotton, sugarcane, pepper and vegetables have been fed mostly by canals from the Krishna and a few wells. The dam has clearly made a huge difference in these parts. My driver is Suresh, a twenty-six-year-old from Vijayawada, who has a diploma in mechanical engineering. Last year, he quit a company job in Hyderabad and returned to live with his family after his father, a forty-eight-year-old labourer, suffered a head injury and ‘lost his mind’. As the elder of two children, Suresh is now the de facto head of the household, a heavy burden at his age.